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Social Media: Detriment or Advantage

Introduction and Background

Social media platforms are often described as “neutral tools,” where they passively assist with community and connection. However, many of their most common features are intentionally engineered to casino level of social engineering to compete for user attention through personalization, rapid responses (Fear of missing out), and frictionless consumption (Odgers & Jensen, 2020). In other words, social media companies want to keep users on their applications for as long as possible. Here, the “addictive nature” of social media can be defined as neurotic or compulsively hard-to-control patterns of use that continue despite attempts to stop and then interfere with everyday responsibilities, relationships, sleep, or mood. This would fit the definition of addiction but not every heavy user meets the afore mentioned clinical criteria for addiction (Nagata et al., 2025). Because of the engineering feedback loop that leading platforms use to continually test and optimize features that keep people engaged, the ethicality of the social media platforms probes the question: when companies design their products with the goal to maximize time-on-app, what responsibility do companies have for predictable compulsive use, especially among the developing minds of adolescents? This question is not theoretical. In a 2024 national survey, Pew Research Center found that nearly half of U.S. teens stated being online “almost constantly,” across several different types of social media applications (Faverio & Sidoti, 2024).

The stakes are high because overwhelmingly compulsive engagement can influence multiple aspects of an adolescent’s well-being during development and later in life. Research correlate “problematic social media use” with symptoms of depression, anxiety, and stress,

showing statistically significant associations across studies (Shannon et al., 2022). Correlation is not causation definitively in this case and correlation may be bidirectional, meaning mental health deteriorated people gravitate more “problematic social media use” perhaps in an effort to connect. In addition, a clinical dialogue in the Journal of the American Medical Association, JAMA, highlights that “addictive” screen use can include patterns of difficulty stopping, increased tolerance, and withdrawal, and other reports stating that young adolescents describe losing track of device usage and struggles to scale back overindulgence of social media (Nagata et al., 2025). These patterns are ethically striking because adolescents are still developing self-regulation skills and are especially sensitive to peer pressure and judgement and the dopamine kick that comes from social reward in the form of “likes”. All those dynamics social platforms can amplify (Sherman et al., 2016). At the same time, digital media effects are not uniform; symptoms and outcomes can vary by individual vulnerabilities, familial and extra-familial contexts, as well as how technology is used. The lack of uniformity obscures simple cause-and-effect claims (Odgers & Jensen, 2020).

Concerns about social media “addiction” intensified as platforms evolved from early networked communication tools into an automated system that algorithmically curated content for advertising-driven services to monetize attention. Over time, interpersonal networking features like chronological feeds were limited and gave way to recommender systems, engagement ranking, and design features such as endless feeds, autoplay, and frequent tempting notification. Features that encourage repeated checking and longer sessions. Metrics such as the “like” button and other similar to it are the core mechanism to quantifying social reward and encouraging peer-influenced engagement. There is evidence that adolescents respond strongly, both behaviorally and neurologically, to peer approval signals online (Sherman et al., 2016).

Because companies measure retention with session length, and return frequency in real time, they can plausibly anticipate when user's choices have reached a compulsive effect. Because companies have the ability to measure and determine success in this manner, it raises questions about whether profit incentives should be regulated for duties to reduce foreseeable harm (Odgers & Jensen, 2020).

Stakeholder Analysis

This issue creates a conflict between two primary stakeholder groups. Stakeholder 1 consists of social media companies, including platform owners and the advertisers and investors whose returns depend on the profitability of engagement metrics. The 2nd Stakeholder includes the adolescents and their families, as well as public health advocates and regulators focused on protecting the well-being of the youth. The conflict is structural in that many platform business models incentivize increased time-on-app, while the potential costs of compulsive engagement can fall disproportionately on young users and those that care for them (Shannon et al., 2022).

Stakeholder 1: Social Media Companies

For social media companies, the highest priorities tend to be profitability, growth, and market competitiveness, which are closely tied to keeping users active on the platform and returning frequently. Because most major platforms rely heavily on advertising or attention-based monetization, metrics such as engagement, time-on-app, and retention function as core indicators of product success and business health. At the same time, companies often emphasize values such as innovation freedom (the ability to test and roll out new features quickly) and user autonomy, framing their platforms as tools that people choose to use in different ways depending on their needs and circumstances (Odgers & Jensen, 2020; OpenAI, 2026). They also have a strong interest in brand trust and legitimacy, since public concerns about teen wellbeing,

problematic use, or platform safety can increase regulatory pressure and damage long-term user confidence (Shannon et al., 2022; Faverio & Sidoti, 2024; OpenAI, 2026).

Social media companies typically take the position that they have a responsibility to provide baseline safety and appropriate safeguards (especially for minors), but they resist the idea that they should be held broadly responsible for “addiction” outcomes in the general sense. The facts and events around teen social media use matter to them because adolescents represent a major and visible user group, and heightened public concern—supported by evidence that problematic use exists for a subset of youth—can translate into lawsuits, regulation, and costly product changes (Shannon et al., 2022; Faverio & Sidoti, 2024; OpenAI, 2026). At the same time, companies point to research emphasizing that the relationship between digital technology and adolescent mental health is complex, varies by individual context, and cannot be reduced to simple “screen time” measures—arguments that support a preference for targeted, evidence-based interventions rather than broad mandates that could reduce engagement and revenue (Odgers & Jensen, 2020; Nagata et al., 2025; OpenAI, 2026). They also pay attention to research showing how platform features (like “likes”) shape teen behavior because it signals where criticism or regulatory focus may concentrate and where they may need to adjust design choices to reduce risk without undermining the platform’s core appeal (Sherman et al., 2016; OpenAI, 2026).

Social media companies commonly rely on multiple claim types to defend a limited-responsibility stance. Definition claims assert that “addiction” implies clinical-level impairment and therefore should not be applied broadly to typical platform use; instead, concern should focus on specific “addictive screen use patterns” or “problematic social media use” that affect only a subset of users (Nagata et al., 2025; Shannon et al., 2022; OpenAI, 2026). Claims of fact

emphasize that findings on mental health impacts are often mixed, context dependent, and variable across individuals, supporting the argument that universal design restrictions may be unjustified (Odgers & Jensen, 2020; OpenAI, 2026). Causal claims argue that adolescent mental health trends have many drivers and that platform design is not the sole or necessarily dominant cause of negative outcomes—an argument consistent with calls in the literature to avoid simplistic cause-and-effect conclusions (Odgers & Jensen, 2020; OpenAI, 2026). Companies may also use analogy claims, suggesting that platforms resemble other general-purpose technologies whose harms are best managed through user education and targeted safeguards rather than sweeping bans. Finally, value claims prioritize autonomy, innovation, and free expression, contending that interventions should preserve user choice while addressing clear, measurable risks—especially for minors (Odgers & Jensen, 2020; Sherman et al., 2016; OpenAI, 2026).

Stakeholder 2: Adolescents, Families, and Public Health Advocates/Regulators

Stakeholder 2 prioritizes healthy adolescent development and digital environments that are set to the safest settings by default. Families and public health advocates value transparency on how social media platforms rank content and utilize engagement and retention features. They emphasize fairness when it comes to most vulnerable part of the stakeholders because minors are still developing self-regulation and are sensitive to peer assessments, making them more susceptible to persuasive social engagement feedback systems (Sherman et al., 2016).

This group of adolescents, their caregivers, and public health advocates and regulators argues that platforms bear significant responsibility because the platforms are built by design to profit from engagement systems that can encourage compulsive patterns in youth. The scale of exposure to online platform is nearly half of all youth (Faverio & Sidoti, 2024). When coinciding

teens report describe difficulty controlling use and negative mental health effects in daily functioning, the user's "choice" alone becomes an incomplete ethical explanation (Nagata et al., 2025).

Stakeholder 2 uses causality claims about the implemented reinforcement mechanisms, such as likes, algorithmic feeds, and notifications, promote repeated checking, social comparison. The stakeholders also use factual claims linking problematic social media use like doomscrolling, constant refreshing, etc. connected with depression, anxiety, and stress (Shannon et al., 2022). Finally, value and analogy claims contend that it is wrong to profit from predictably compulsive features greatly effect susceptible minors and that influential design should be regulated, similar to safety standards in other risk-bearing industries like gambling.

Argument Question

Should social media companies be ethically responsible for reducing addictive design features in products used by adolescents, even if such actions decrease engagement and revenue?

Stakeholder Arguments

Stakeholder 1 Argument: Harm Principle and Individual Autonomy

The ethical framework of harm reduction and autonomy draws from public health ethics and classical liberal philosophy, particularly the work of John Stuart Mill in *On Liberty* (1859) and later harm-reduction approaches developed in late 20th-century public health policy. Mill's harm principle holds that individual liberty should only be limited to prevent harm to others, establishing autonomy as a central moral value. Modern harm-reduction theory, influenced by public health scholars and bioethicists, expands this idea by recognizing that risky behaviors will occur and that the ethical goal is not necessarily prohibition, but the minimization of preventable harm while preserving personal freedom. Major principles of this framework include respect for

individual choice, proportional intervention (responses should match the severity and evidence of harm), evidence-based policy, and protection of vulnerable populations. Rather than banning potentially harmful activities outright, harm reduction seeks practical strategies—such as safer defaults, transparency, and protective safeguards—that reduce negative outcomes without eliminating autonomy. In essence, the framework attempts to balance two ethical goals: maximizing wellbeing by reducing foreseeable harm and preserving individual liberty by avoiding unnecessary paternalistic restriction (OpenAI, 2026).

Using a harm-reduction and autonomy framework, social media companies can argue that the most ethical approach is to reduce predictable, preventable harms while preserving user choice rather than imposing sweeping limits that treat all engagement as inherently harmful. Because teen social media use is widespread, a core autonomy claim is that platforms should remain usable for connection, learning, and community, while giving users and families meaningful tools to manage their own boundaries (Faverio & Sidoti, 2024; Odgers & Jensen, 2020; OpenAI, 2026). From a harm-reduction angle, companies can justify focusing interventions on high-risk patterns (e.g., compulsive late-night checking, repeated “automatic” re-entry, or escalation into problematic use) by adjusting defaults and offering controls—such as notification management, screen-time settings, and age-appropriate guardrails—rather than eliminating major features for everyone (Nagata et al., 2025; Shannon et al., 2022; OpenAI, 2026). They can also argue that because specific design elements can amplify peer influence and reinforcement (e.g., “likes”), ethically responsible harm reduction supports targeted design options (like reducing social comparison cues or giving users more control over feedback visibility) without stripping away user autonomy broadly (Sherman et al., 2016; OpenAI, 2026).

From the companies’ perspective, the “correct” course of action is a proportionate, evidence-guided, least-restrictive strategy: strengthen safety and reduce foreseeable harms—especially for minors—while avoiding blanket mandates that assume uniform harm or a single causal driver. The research base frequently emphasizes that digital effects are heterogeneous and context dependent, which supports a policy posture that prioritizes user choice and targeted protections over one-size-fits-all restrictions (Odgers & Jensen, 2020; OpenAI, 2026). At the same time, scholarship distinguishing addictive patterns of use from simple “screen time” supports interventions that specifically interrupt compulsive loops (e.g., reducing interruptive prompts, adding friction to repeated checking behaviors, or offering stronger bedtime settings) rather than banning social features outright (Nagata et al., 2025; OpenAI, 2026). Companies can also point to the value of using rigorous evidence—including experimental and quasi-experimental approaches that examine how changes in platform access relate to emotional state—to justify incremental changes and continual evaluation rather than immediate, broad redesign requirements that may produce unintended tradeoffs (Allcott et al., 2025; OpenAI, 2026).

If the outcome supports a harm-reduction-with-autonomy standard (targeted safeguards, transparent controls, and protective defaults for youth), companies stand to gain by preserving engagement-driven business viability while reducing reputational, legal, and regulatory risk tied to concerns about problematic use (Shannon et al., 2022; OpenAI, 2026). They also benefit by aligning with the reality that teen social media use is deeply embedded in daily life—meaning solutions that preserve access while reducing harm are less likely to trigger backlash from users who rely on platforms for communication and community (Faverio & Sidoti, 2024; OpenAI, 2026). Conversely, if the decision outcome imposes strong obligations to remove or substantially

weaken engagement-optimizing mechanics across the board, companies could lose significant revenue, retention, and product flexibility, and face costly redesign demands—especially in a research landscape that highlights mixed impacts and multiple drivers of adolescent mental health beyond any single technology (Odgers & Jensen, 2020; OpenAI, 2026). However, if companies resist meaningful harm reduction entirely, they risk greater long-term losses: increasing evidence that problematic patterns exist for a meaningful subset of users and that certain feedback mechanisms shape teen behavior can intensify public pressure for stricter regulation and greater liability exposure (Nagata et al., 2025; Sherman et al., 2016; OpenAI, 2026).

Stakeholder 2 Argument: Utilitarianism

Utilitarianism is a consequentialist ethical framework most closely associated with Jeremy Bentham (1748–1832) and later refined by John Stuart Mill (1806–1873). Bentham introduced the principle of utility, arguing that actions are morally right if they promote the “greatest happiness of the greatest number.” He proposed that pleasure and pain are the fundamental measures of moral value and even suggested a “hedonic calculus” to evaluate outcomes based on intensity, duration, and scope. Mill expanded the theory by distinguishing between higher and lower pleasures, emphasizing that intellectual and moral pleasures carry greater weight than purely physical ones. The central goal of utilitarianism is to maximize overall wellbeing (utility) and minimize suffering for the largest number of people affected by a decision. Key principles include impartiality (each person’s happiness counts equally), outcome-based evaluation (the morality of an action depends on its consequences rather than intentions), and aggregate welfare (decisions should consider total net benefit across society). In practice, utilitarianism supports policies or actions that produce the greatest overall balance of benefits

over harms, even if doing so requires limiting certain individual preferences when broader social wellbeing is at stake (OpenAI, 2026).

From a utilitarian perspective, adolescents, families, and public health advocates and regulators contend that the most ethical policy is one that maximizes net well-being for the largest number of people. This means that social media platform design should be governed and judged according to their overall impact on youth. Mental health, sleep, development, and safety, are to be prioritized over company profits or convenience. Given the prevalence of teen social media use, even modest increases in negative outcomes can result in significant population-level consequences. Such consequences can follow adolescents progress into adulthood. This bolsters the utilitarian rationale and encourages the need for intervention (Faverio & Sidoti, 2024). The stakeholders advocate for practical, evidence-based changes that address the most predictable risks of addictive screen use patterns, such as compulsive late-night checking, repeated cycles of re-engagement, and reinforcement-driven behaviors which can cause sleep disruption, mood problems, or compulsive use patterns. The stakeholders believe that companies can still maintain positive aspects like connection and access to information without exploiting youths (Nagata et al., 2025; Odgers & Jensen, 2020). The evidence demonstrates the existence of problematic social media use among adolescents and young adults, therefore supporting targeted safeguards prioritizes those most affected for the greatest net wellbeing (Shannon et al., 2022).

From a utilitarian viewpoint, this stakeholder contends that the ethical obligation is to implement safety-by-design modifications centered on youth, aiming to maximize overall benefit—mitigating widespread harms while maintaining valuable opportunities for online connection and information. Although scholars emphasize that digital-age mental health effects are complex and not uniform across all adolescents, utilitarianism does not require perfect

certainty; it supports action when the expected consequences of policy are likely to reduce overall suffering, particularly for vulnerable users. The presence of problematic social media use at significant rates, recognition of "addictive screen use patterns" as distinct from mere screen time, and evidence from experimental changes in platform access impacting emotional well-being (Allcott et al., 2025) together support interventions that lessen the chances and severity of harmful behaviors. Consequently, this perspective favors enforceable standards for minors because these interventions are warranted if they increase youth wellbeing more than they diminish overall utility.

If social media companies are genuinely tasked with addressing addictive design features, adolescents and their families stand to benefit most from a utilitarian perspective: average wellbeing would likely improve, with fewer harmful usage patterns and less pressure on parents and teens to counteract platforms engineered for habitual engagement (Nagata et al., 2025; Shannon et al., 2022). For public health professionals and regulators, this creates opportunities for broad, quantifiable gains in societal welfare, as widespread teen usage means even modest improvements per individual can yield significant overall benefits (Faverio & Sidoti, 2024). Conversely, if corporate responsibility remains limited, vulnerable youth may continue to face engagement mechanisms linked to problematic behaviors and reinforcement-driven pressures (Shannon et al., 2022; Sherman et al., 2016). Although increased intervention may reduce convenience, novelty, or engagement for some users, this tradeoff is ethically justified within utilitarianism if the net outcome favors greater wellbeing, especially considering the well-established evidence of problematic use and the role platform design can play in shaping emotional states across large populations (Allcott et al., 2025; Shannon et al., 2022).

Student Position

This paper argues that social media companies have a significant ethical responsibility to limit addictive design features in products used by adolescents. The issue is not that platforms are directly responsible for every case of anxiety or depression, but rather, it's that companies deliberately design engagement systems and can reasonably predict that elements like frequent notifications, endless feeds, and visible social rewards encourage compulsive use among young users (Nagata et al., 2025; Sherman et al., 2016). There are more teens than ever reporting near-constant online activity, these risks shift from niche isolated incidents to widespread societal concerns, justifying ethical limitations on design (Faverio & Sidoti, 2024).

This perspective aligns with Stakeholder 2's utilitarian focus on reducing harm and maximizing well-being, especially since studies link problematic social media use with higher rates of depression, anxiety, and stress (Shannon et al., 2022). Still, Social Media companies in Stakeholder 1's emphasis on autonomy deserves attention in that digital media effects are not uniform or consistent among users and usage, and overly broad policies may restrict positive uses or exaggerate causal claims (Odgers & Jensen, 2020). Ethical responsibility should therefore be viewed as a heightened duty of care specifically for youth accounts and related features and not a blanket assertion that all platform engagement is unethical or that adults lack self-direction.

A practical solution is a "duty of care and safety-by-design" model tailored to minors. Youth accounts would automatically have protective settings, such as fewer notifications, clear stopping points in feeds, and barriers to late-night usage. Platforms should also increase transparency by revealing their main engagement strategies for youth and permitting independent audits of feature changes impacting app usage time and return rates. Additionally, companies

would be required to assess foreseeable harms before launching new youth-targeted engagement features, much like safety testing in other sectors. This strategy maintains adult autonomy while offering stronger protections for more vulnerable users, and fits utilitarian principles by promoting overall well-being without prohibiting social media altogether (Allcott et al., 2025).

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